

Meta-worse?

IN MY 20 YEARS OF REPORTING AND OPINING ON TECHNOLOGY, ONE THING THAT HAS STOOD OUT IS THE FACT THAT WE TEND TO GET VERY, VERY EXCITED BY EVERYTHING NEW. At Team Digit, we're usually the earliest of the early adopters, and sometimes get access to technology before the general public even knows it exists. This tends to make us believe that things will be as good or bad as we think they are when we geeks experience them. We look at them through our own lens, imagine them in our own lives, and generally love most new things. Why? Because being exposed to tech as much as we are, means we're a pretty jaded bunch, and anything new is a break from the humdrum normalcy of what most would consider to be cutting edge tech.

In short. We tech reviewers and tech journalists are a pretty spoiled bunch. And this is not just true for Digit, but most tech journalists around the world. Some of us know how privileged we are, others take it for granted, but all of us at times can act like excited little toddlers around tech.

So what happens when the world is going ga-ga over the metaverse? We're either super-excited and reporting everything that's happening (thus our cover story), knowing fully well that the majority of new tech ventures fail miserably. Or we're sitting down, playing the part of the wise old owl, and writing columns about how the metaverse will suck, or be bad for us, and yes, I'm very much adding myself to that second category.

Hey, at least give me a little credit for knowing that I'm being cliché and openly acknowledging it!

However, my critique of the metaverse is less to do with the technology that drives the metaverse itself, which is what we have covered in the cover story this month, and more to do with the effects it might have on societies, especially ours. It's important we realise how this will affect us all, and not just us geeks, who are the target audience.

And the metaverse is certainly targeted at a specific group of people, for now. It's being built for those in the west with disposable incomes, enough to be able to afford decent hardware, and who are generally gamers. Those will be the early adopters, and as a result, most new services will be targeted at them. They're the ones who will buy into the new services, and

money makes the world go round. No company is interested in anything but being successful and growing at a rapid pace – and why not? Nothing wrong with wanting to be successful!

How does this help those of us who can't afford a few lakh in hardware to get the optimum experience that others will enjoy? It doesn't. Not yet. Thankfully, India being as innovative as it is, I foresee a whole host of different offerings meant just for us. We will have metaverses that are not segregated by experience but by vernacular languages perhaps. We will see innovation in hardware and services that will help drive the adoption for the majority of the rest of the world. But when? That's the question.

Large corporations are juggernauts. We need speedboats for the Indian market, not behemoths that are slow to turn and react because they carry the weight of many, many passengers. The largest corporations however make the rules, and set the tone for the direction of research and development. They're the ones the little companies try and please and get noticed by.

We need Indian companies to stand up, do the research and build our own metaverses that aren't just copies of western culture and services. Since the metaverse is a big enough change in the way we use the internet, we need originality from the start. Doing what we normally do, and just slightly modifying the offerings and trying to force fit them to India is the 'meta-worse' I'm talking about in the headline.

Admittedly this month's cover story doesn't look for Indian companies and what they're doing, because (perhaps) it is still early days. However, we promise to find truly-Indian solutions and innovations, and report them to you via this mag and our website. What we ask from you in return is to support those companies and use their products, encourage them to do better and improve, and to look at us here in India as the way we are – uniquely Indian.

And if you are already running such a company or working at one, drop us an email, let us know what you're working on and we will do our best to let our readers know about you.

Here's looking forward to a made for India metaverse that we can all enjoy. If we grab our opportunity and do this right, instead of a meta-worse, we have a chance to have (pardon the slightly cringe phrase) a better-meta! 



“...my critique of the metaverse is less to do with the technology that drives the metaverse itself... and more to do with the effects it might have on societies”



Liked or hated this column? Let me know at: robert@digit.in | facebook.com/raaabo | [@raaabo](https://t.me/raaabo) | t.me/digitgeek | discord.gg/myD8XVt | WhatsApp: +91 98211 69631